



rights remain the single biggest contributor to the league's rapid financial expansion.

"Fans, too, haven't played a role yet. It's primarily the media rights right now," he said.

"Ticketing hasn't played a role yet, nor has merchandising, because we are still a relatively young league. For now, we are seeing limited fan bases in pockets, in Bengaluru to a certain extent, in Mumbai and Chennai. That's it currently... Nobody has asked why it is limited to only three franchises."

According to Modi, only a few early franchise owners invested significantly in developing team identities beyond on-field performances, focussing on brand-building initiatives that helped create loyal fan communities.

"Vijay Mallya was a showman. His brand was associated with the spirits business, and he spent out-of-proportion money building the base with a liquor brand. With the Mumbai Indians, the Mukesh Ambani family went out of their way. N. Srinivasan did a very smart thing with India Cements buying Chennai Super Kings. A lot of investment was done in building fan bases," he said.

"None of the other teams did significant brand extension or

marketing. They built the team based on personalities and media rights and did no brand building at all."

Modi also recalled the strategic importance of bringing Bollywood superstar Shah Rukh Khan on board as co-owner of Kolkata Knight Riders, a move he considers central to the league's early mass appeal beyond traditional cricket audiences.

"I needed women and children to watch the league, and for that, I needed Shah Rukh. He was a very big part of the IPL and it was do-or-die for me," Modi said.

"That's why the first match was purposely scheduled as a clash between the teams owned by Shah Rukh Khan and Vijay Mallya in Bengaluru. It was not KKR versus RCB. Nobody knew KKR and RCB in those days. The headline was Shah Rukh Khan versus Vijay Mallya."

IPL is 'recession-proof'

Soon after the inaugural season in 2008, the global financial crisis cast doubts over the sustainability of major sporting investments worldwide. However, at the 2009 players' auction in Goa, Modi declared that the IPL was recession-proof, a claim he continues to stand by nearly two decades later.

"The IPL is on the cusp of

Immersive cricket: For Lalit Modi, the next IPL leap lies not on the pitch, but in turning match-day into an experience. THE HINDU PHOTO LIBRARY

dominating the world. Earlier, we were dependent on broadcasters through television networks and cable. Data was expensive and the world was still small. Today, viewing has shifted to multiple devices," he said.

"90 per cent of the business lies here. You don't need a cable operator, you don't need fibre, you don't need a broadcaster. Now it can be streamed directly."

Modi emphasised that advertising continues to form the backbone of the league's commercial structure, with innovations such as the strategic timeout designed specifically to expand advertising inventory.

"Our market is still advertisement driven. We are sustaining this growth only on advertising, and we are still a fraction of the revenue advertisers are willing to pay for an IPL spot.

"I never sold media rights; I sold 2,600 seconds in my media product. I created a paradigm of selling slots between overs and across digital platforms. I moved it from 2,000 seconds to 2,600 seconds with the strategic timeout because I didn't have enough advertising inventory. It was done purely for commercial purposes."

Improving infrastructure and enhancing fan experience

While franchise owners have increasingly expanded into overseas T20 leagues in recent years, Modi believes these investments will not dilute the IPL's dominance, primarily because Indian players remain restricted from participating in most foreign leagues.

"The Indian players can never play outside of India, period," Modi said. "It's enshrined in my IPL contract, it's enshrined in everything that we do. So, even if the owners go anywhere, it won't have an impact."

However, he stressed that improving stadium infrastructure and overall fan experience should be